

- RAG Learning

3.4 Nationalism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Nationalism holds that humanity is naturally divided into **nations**, and that the nation should be the primary focus of political loyalty and the basis of political organisation. It is unusual among ideologies in being **cross-cutting**: it attaches to others rather than standing alone, which is why it has produced both national liberation and genocide from the same starting premise.

Optional ideology. Students study *one* of nationalism, feminism, multiculturalism, anarchism or ecologism.

AQA key thinkers for nationalism: Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Johann Herder, Giuseppe Mazzini, Marcus Garvey and Charles Maurras.

1. Core ideas

The nation

A group sharing a common culture, language, history, traditions or identity, whose members see themselves as a distinct people. Crucially, a nation is **not the same as a state**: a nation can exist without one (the Kurds), and a state can contain several nations (the UK).

Self-determination

The core *political* demand: a nation has the right to govern itself rather than be ruled by another people or an external power. This connects the cultural claim that a nation exists to the political claim that it should have a state.

The nation-state

The ideal that political and national boundaries should coincide. This is nationalism's practical programme — and its central practical difficulty, since populations are rarely neatly distributed. The post-1918 redrawing of European borders on self-determination principles left substantial minorities stranded, which became a source of grievance and eventually war.

Culturalism

Emphasis on a nation's distinctive language, customs, folklore and history — Herder's **Volksgeist**. Cultural nationalism can exist without demanding statehood.

Racialism

Some nationalisms define the nation by descent and biology rather than culture or citizenship, producing exclusion of those without the relevant ancestry. This is the variant responsible for nationalism's worst outcomes.

2. Civic vs ethnic nationalism

	Civic nationalism	Ethnic nationalism
Defines the nation by	Shared political values, institutions and citizenship	Common descent, ancestry, language, cultural inheritance
Membership	Voluntary — open in principle to anyone who accepts the values	Inherited — those without the ancestry cannot fully belong
Character	Inclusive; compatible with diversity	Exclusive
Associated with	Liberal nationalism; the American and French revolutionary traditions	Romantic and integral nationalism

Exam Tip: This distinction largely determines whether a given nationalism tends towards liberal self-determination or towards expulsion and conflict. It is the single most useful analytical tool in the topic — apply it to any nationalism you are asked to evaluate.

3. Key thinkers

Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778) — *The Social Contract* (1762)

- **The general will** — sovereignty resides in the collective will of the people, directed at the common good rather than at private interests.
- **Popular sovereignty** — legitimate government derives from the people as a collective body, not from a monarch.
- **Why he matters** — he predates nationalism proper, but his idea that a *people* is the source of authority provided the foundation for the claim that nations should rule themselves. Nationalism is in this sense a child of the idea of popular sovereignty.

Johann Herder (1744–1803)

- **Volksgeist** — each people possesses a unique spirit or character, expressed in its language, folklore, customs and history.
- **Cultural nationalism** — the priority is the preservation and celebration of that distinctiveness, not necessarily statehood.
- **Cultural pluralism** — crucially, Herder celebrated the distinctiveness of *all* cultures, implying their equal worth rather than any hierarchy. He was not a chauvinist.
- **Against Enlightenment universalism** — he denied that there is a single universal standard of civilisation against which peoples can be ranked.

Giuseppe Mazzini (1805–1872)

- **Liberal nationalism** — every nation has an *equal* right to self-determination; nations are like individuals, each entitled to freedom.
- **Nationalism and internationalism are compatible** — a world of free, self-governing nations would cooperate peacefully.
- **Duty and action** — nation-building requires active civic participation and moral duty, not merely sentiment.
- **Italian unification** — his practical project, and the model for liberal nationalist movements across Europe.

Marcus Garvey (1887–1940)

- **Black nationalism and pan-Africanism** — a response to slavery, colonialism and racial oppression.
- **Racial pride and self-reliance** — black people should take pride in their African heritage and build their own institutions and economic power rather than seek acceptance from white society.
- **Separatism and return** — he advocated a connection to, and for some a return to, an African homeland.
- **Significance** — he shows nationalism functioning as a vehicle of *liberation* for an oppressed and dispersed people, which complicates any simple account of nationalism as reactionary.

Charles Maurras (1868–1952)

- **Integral nationalism** — the nation is an organic whole to which the individual is entirely subordinate.
- **Authoritarian and anti-democratic** — hostile to liberalism, democracy and parliamentary government, which he saw as dividing the nation.
- **Exclusive** — the nation defined by descent and inherited culture; outsiders, particularly Jews, treated as alien and corrupting.
- **Hierarchy and tradition** — a monarchist and reactionary, associated with *Action Française*.

4. Types of nationalism

Type	Character	Examples
Liberal	Civic; every nation has an equal right to self-determination; compatible with internationalism	Mazzini; Italian and German unification; Wilson's Fourteen Points
Conservative	Emphasises tradition, shared culture and organic unity; defensive; used to bind society against division	Disraeli's imperial patriotism; much modern populist nationalism

Anti-colonial / postcolonial	Independence from imperial rule, often fused with socialist analysis of economic exploitation	Gandhi, Nkrumah; Garvey's pan-Africanism
Expansionist	Chauvinistic; asserts national superiority; justifies domination or conquest	Maurras's integral nationalism; the extreme nationalisms of the twentieth century

5. Tensions between the thinkers

Disagreement	One side	The other
Are nations equal?	Mazzini — equal right to freedom; universalisable	Maurras — the nation is superior; cannot be universalised without contradiction
Cultural or political?	Herder — the nation is a cultural community; statehood not essential	Rousseau, Mazzini — the nation is a political community exercising sovereignty
Inclusive or exclusive?	Civic — membership by shared values, open to all	Ethnic — membership inherited; outsiders excluded
Relationship to the individual	Liberal — the nation serves the freedom of its members	Integral — the individual is subordinate to the nation

Exam Tip: Mazzini and Maurras do not differ by degree but by **logical form**. Mazzini's principle can be granted to everyone; Maurras's cannot be universalised, because it asserts *particular* superiority. This is the strongest evidence that nationalism is not a single coherent ideology — the two positions share only the vocabulary of the nation.

6. Are nations natural or constructed?

- **Primordialism** — nations are ancient, organic and pre-political. This is what nationalists themselves generally assume, and it grounds the claim that nations deserve self-government.
- **Modernism** — nations were *produced* by print capitalism, mass education, industrialisation and state-building, and are "imagined communities" whose members never meet yet feel a shared bond.

This is the most serious intellectual challenge to nationalism: if nations are recent constructions, the claim that they represent a natural basis for political organisation is undermined. **The nationalist reply** is that constructed identities are entirely real in their effects — people demonstrably feel national loyalty and act on it, whatever its historical origin.

7. Liberation or oppression?

Nationalism as liberation	Nationalism as oppression
Freed peoples from imperial and autocratic rule — Italian and German unification, the end of the Austro-Hungarian and Ottoman empires	Where the nation is ethnic and organic, and superiority is asserted, it has justified conquest, expulsion and genocide
Drove twentieth-century anti-colonial movements across Asia and Africa	Maurras's integral nationalism; the extreme nationalisms of the 1930s
Garvey's black nationalism asserted dignity against racial oppression	Ethnic cleansing during the break-up of Yugoslavia
Extended self-government to people explicitly denied it	Defining a nation necessarily identifies outsiders

Why both are possible: nationalism is cross-cutting. Combined with liberalism it produces Mazzini's universal self-determination; with reactionary conservatism, Maurras. The premise that peoples should govern themselves *does not by itself determine who counts as the people* — and that question is answered by whichever ideology nationalism has fused with.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Nation	A group sharing culture, language, history or identity who see themselves as a people
Nation-state	A sovereign state whose boundaries coincide with a nation
Self-determination	A nation's right to govern itself
Volksgeist	The unique spirit or character of a people (Herder)
General will	The collective will of a people directed at the common good (Rousseau)
Civic nationalism	The nation defined by shared political values and citizenship
Ethnic nationalism	The nation defined by common descent and inherited culture
Integral nationalism	Organic, authoritarian, exclusive nationalism subordinating the individual (Maurras)
Chauvinism	Belief in national superiority justifying domination of others
Pan-nationalism	Unifying a dispersed people across states (pan-Africanism, pan-Slavism)
Imagined community	The view that national identity is socially constructed rather than natural
Irredentism	Claiming territory held by another state on the grounds that co-nationals live there